



Hub of activity: In January, the Nawang Dorjay Stobdan Stadium ice rink hosted the second consecutive season of the Royal Enfield Ice Hockey League, attracting crowds with over 6,000 attendees at some matches. SHASHISHEKHAR KASHYAP

floods that we didn't in the past. Last summer was extremely hot – something we hadn't experienced before – and the winter started late."

The Hindu Kush Himalaya Assessment of 2019 warns that nearly two-thirds of the glaciers along the Hindu Kush and Himalaya ranges will vanish by 2100 at the current rate of carbon emissions. Even if emissions are drastically reduced to limit global warming to 1.5°C, glacier loss would still amount to 36 per cent.

A silver lining

For ice hockey, however, there is a glimmer of hope.

In February 2024, Lieutenant Governor Brigadier (Dr) BD Mishra (Retired) inaugurated the renovation and improvement of the Karzoo pond.

The Centre is also overseeing the construction of a rink at the Nawang Dorjay Stobdan Stadium, which, currently natural, will be converted

into an artificial rink by 2026.

"The foundation stone was laid in 2007, but construction picked up speed after Ladakh became a union territory. Since over 97 per cent of the national team comes from Ladakh, this rink is crucial for players here to improve their game," Namgyal explains.

The venue has become a hub for competitive ice hockey in Ladakh, hosting the CEC Championship since 2020 and the Khelo India Winter Games (KIWG) ice hockey tournament since last year.

In January, the rink hosted the second consecutive season of the Royal Enfield Ice Hockey League, attracting capacity crowds, with over 6,000 attendees at some matches.

"This rink meets international standards (30 metres by 60 metres, according to the International Ice Hockey Federation). The roofing is nearly complete, and so is the seating," says PT Kunzang,

vice-president of the Ice Hockey Association of Ladakh.

The 2025 edition of the KIWG is scheduled here in February, with plans to make the rink operational year-round.

"By March, the cooling plant will be installed, and by September or October, it will be generating artificial ice. Currently, we play only during winter, but once the plant is ready, our children will be able to play year-round," Kunzang adds.

Professional ice hockey, with urban infrastructure, seems poised to thrive in Ladakh. But the climate, snow, and cold season – integral to nurturing the next generation and creating an avenue for the sport to flourish in a largely warm country – face an uncertain future amidst a rapidly changing environment.

'Winter has come' still brings smiles to every Ladakhi. But how long will it stay?